TIME IS A CLOSET

Art and Story by **Mei Fujimatsu**

THE INCOMPLETE FLOWER

THEY SAID YAYA...

...WAS AN INCOMPLETE FLOWER.

FATHER TOLD YOU NOT TO COME HERE, DIDN'T HE?

RUSTLE

YAYA!

MURMUR

BUT YOU'RE FILTHY.

SMILE

DID YOU COME TO SEE OUR SPLENDID COING-OF-AGE ATTIRE?

OR I'LL TELL FATHER.

CLENCH

GO BACK TO WORK.

DASH

MY, MY.

SHE'S AS GOOD AS ABANDONED.

GASP

UGLY, AND STUPID AS A DOG. THEY OUGHT TO THROW HER AWAY ALREADY.

WHAT A HATEFUL CHILD.

BEING A LOOKOUT OUTSIDE THE VILLAGE...

DRIP...

POUR...

IT'S RAINING...

MY ELDER SISTERS' OUTFITS...

...WILL GET WET...

THOSE RED, FRILLY OUTFITS... THEY WERE SO BEAUTIFUL...

STEP

I WONDER WHEN YAYA WILL REACH HER LIMIT?

YOU'RE FILTHY.

RISE

SMILE

STILL FILTHY...

SPLASH

DASH

SLAP

SLAP

BLUB BLUB

WHAT DO I DO?

IT GOT TANGLED.

GASP

FLICK

FLICK

BLINK

DID YAYA DIE?

WHOOSH!

SNAP

HUH???

SHALL WE GET CHANGED?

WHO... ARE YOU?

SO FLUFFY...?

SHOULD I MAKE IT FRILLY?

THE PRETTIEST ONE?

RUSTLE

MM-HM, IT'S CALLED FRILLS.

TAP

FRILLY?

HUFF!

LIKE THIS.

WANT TO TRY IT ON?

. . . . . !

IT SEEMS LIKE YOU LOVE CLOTHES.

I'VE NEVER SEEN ANYTHING LIKE IT.

AMAZING!

IT'S SIMPLY JUST AMAZING!

WITH EYES AS BEAUTIFUL AS JEWELS.

SWISH

SO YOUR NAME IS YAYA.

BUT... I AM...

...DIRTY.

HAIR LIKE SILK.

YAYA, YOU'RE LOVELY.

I'LL DRESS YOU.

...OKAY.

SHE SAID I WAS "LOVELY."

IT WAS THE FIRST TIME IN MY LIFE ANYONE HAD SAID THAT TO ME.

YAYA,

YOU'RE A LOW-BORN FOREIGN GIRL FATHER PICKED UP.

A CHILD FATHER MADE ON A WHIM.

YOUR HAIR AND EYES ARE COMPLETELY DIFFERENT FROM OURS.

THEY SAID SHE DIED OF ILLNESS.

YAYA... WHERE IS YOUR MOTHER?

YOU HAVE A ROLE YOU MUST FULFIL.

YAYA, YOU ARE DIFFERENT FROM THE OTHER GIRLS.

IT IS A VERY IMPORTANT ROLE.

YOUR JOB IS TO WARN US.

THERE'S NO KNOWING WHEN THOSE BANDITS MAY ATTACK THE VILLAGE.

STAND WATCH OUTSIDE THE VILLAGE.

DO YOU UNDERSTAND?

FATHER.

YES!

THERE IS NO NEED FOR AN "INCOMPLETE FLOWER" HERE.

WHAT A FOOLISH CHILD.

DONE.

SHALL I CUT YOUR HAIR TOO?

IF YOUR BANGS HANG OVER YOUR FACE,

PAT

PAT

IT'S BAD FOR YOUR EYES.

TWINKL

I'M GOOD AT IT.

CUTE.

SEE?

A DANCE I DIDN'T KNOW.

TURN

!

A SONG I'D NEVER HEARD BEFORE.

...FUN.

YAYA.

MM-HM.

FUN...?

FUN!

CHIRP

DROP

CHIRP

CHIRP

IT FEELS LIKE A DREAM.

WAS IT REALLY A DREAM...??

YAYA.

GOOD DAY,

SO IT WASN'T A DREAM.

WHICH OUTFIT SHALL WE WEAR TODAY?

.....!

I'M HAPPY, SO VERY HAPPY.

SHALL WE GO WITH LOAFERS?

LOAFERS?

IT'S THE NAME OF THIS FOOT-WEAR.

A NAME.

HEELS HURT IF YOU'RE NOT USED TO THEM.

AH.

HAKU.

AND YOUR NAME?

...A NAME.

I'M TRAVELING.

A JOURNEY IN SEARCH OF GARMENTS.

TRAVELING.

...WHY ARE YOU HERE, HAKU?

A JOURNEY IN SEARCH OF CLOTHES.

TO DRESS MYSELF IN ATTIRE MEANT ONLY FOR ME.

THAT IS MY REASON FOR EXISTING.

TO WEAR CLOTHES MEANT ONLY FOR YOU...

ABOUT MY TRAVELS??

SURE.

.....WILL YOU TELL ME ABOUT YOURSELF, HAKU?

YOU HAVE A ROLE YOU MUST FULFIL.

YAYA TOO...!

YAYA.

AND DRESSED ME IN ALL KINDS OF CLOTHES.

SHE CAME EVERY DAY,

AND AFTER THAT, HAKU

...TOLD ME ABOUT HER TRAVELS.

AND STROKED MY HEAD.

SHE ALWAYS PRAISED ME, SAYING, "YOU LOOK LOVELY,"

AND SOMETIMES WE DANCED TOGETHER.

BEFORE LONG, YAYA NEVER WANTED TO BE APART FROM HAKU.

WHOOSH...

IT'S RAINING...

THE DAY I FIRST MET HAKU...

DID YOU WANT TO GO OUTSIDE...?

IF WE GO OUTSIDE,OUR CLOTHES WILL GET WET.

I SUPPOSE SO.

EVEN THOUGH YOUR CLOTHES GOT SOAKED TOO...?

WHY ARE YOU SO KIND TO ME?

HAKU, WHY DID YOU HELP ME?

AND BESIDES,

WILL THE CLOTHES DRY?

IS WAITING FOR YOU.

THE GARMENT MEANT FOR YOU

DO YOU MEAN THE COMING-OF-AGE ATTIRE?

A GARMENT MEANT FOR ME...?

BECAUSE I'M AN "INCOMPLETE FLOWER."

MINE PROBABLY

DOESN'T EXIST.

SQUEEZE

BUT

WHEN WE PUT ON CLOTHES, WE BECOME COMPLETE.

BY WEARING GARMENTS,

WE ARE MADE WHOLE.

WE...?

MM-HM, THE SAME.

AM I THE SAME AS YOU?

SHOW ME

THE MOMENT YAYA BECOMES A FLOWER.

GRAB

MM-HM...!

HAKU.

SPLASH

WILL YOU STAY WITH ME UNTIL I BECOME A FLOWER?

WILL YOU STAY WITH ME FOREVER?

FLASH!

CRACKLE

HUH...?

FLINCH

RUMBLE

.....!

OPEN

SHHHHHHHHHH

...HAKU?

HUSH

YOU THERE.

YOU'LL GET DRENCHED.

HAKU...??

WELL NOW.

COULD YOU PERHAPS BE FROM TATANI VILLAGE UP AHEAD?

I HAVE BUSINESS IN TATANI VILLAGE,

SO WOULD YOU GUIDE ME THERE?

"YOU WANT ME"...?

WHAT?

SHE IS VERY BEAUTIFUL.

I HAVE NEVER SEEN A GIRL WITH SUCH FEATURES BEFORE.

YES, HOWEVER, THAT GIRL IS THE ONE I WANT.

I WAS TOLD ORIGINALLY YOU WANTED ANOTHER GIRL.

UNDERSTOOD....

OTHERWISE, LET US CONSIDER OUR SUPPORT WITHDRAWN.

THEN PLEASE WAIT UNTIL YAYA COMES OF AGE.

I WONDER WHERE SHE SUDDENLY WENT.

HAKU...

JOLT

YAYA.

I WILL EDUCATE YOU BEFORE YOUR COMING OF AGE.

FROM TODAY ONWARD, YOU WILL LIVE HERE.

...NO.

I WON'T BE ABLE TO SEE HAKU ANYMORE.

!

GRAB

I DON'T WANT THAT!

WHERE DID YOU STEAL SOMETHING LIKE THIS FROM?!

MY CLOTHES...!

GLARE

...!!

CLENCH

WHAM

YOU ARE MY "PROPERTY."

DO NOT DEFY ME EVER AGAIN!

SQUEEZE

PLOP

HAKU ISN'T COMING.

LADY YAYA.

SCUFF

AFTER THAT,

HAKU NEVER ONCE APPEARED AGAIN.

LADY YAYA.

HOLD

YOU SAID YOU WANTED

TO SEE ME BECOME A FLOWER...???

WHY...?

WHY DID YOU DISAPPEAR?

WAS IT BECAUSE I LET GO OF YOUR HAND?

IF I BECOME A FLOWER,

WILL YOU COME AGAIN?

PERHAPS HAKU KNEW,

EVERYTHING.

IF ONLY I CAN BECOME A FLOWER...

NOW THAT I THINK OF IT,

LADY YAYA IS BEAUTIFUL TODAY AS WELL.

LADY YAYA....

LADY MEME, WHO WAS MARRIED OFF BEFORE YOU, HER "COUNTRY" HAS NOW GONE TO WAR.

I DO HOPE SHE IS STILL ALIVE.

THE "COUNTRY" YOU ARE TO MARRY INTO, LADY YAYA, IS AT PEACE.

IT'S INCREDIBLY PROSPEROUS!

THE REASON WE CAN LIVE LIKE THIS IS ALL THANKS TO YOU, LADY YAYA.

I CANNOT WAIT FOR TOMORROW'S COMING-OF-AGE CEREMONY.

YES.

YES.

PLEASE REST WELL.

I MUST PREPARE FOR TOMORROW..

PLEASE LEAVE ME ALONE TODAY.

SLIDE

DRAG

JUST ONCE IS ENOUGH.

IF ONLY YOU WOULD COME SEE ME.

HAKU...

THE DAY'S FINALLY COME... IT'S TOMORROW!

AHHHHH

AHHHHHHHHH

FIRE...?

SAVAGES...

THEY'VE SET FIRE!

THOSE SAVAGES!

RUN!

THE ATTIRE...

EVEN THOUGH WE GAVE MEME IN MARRIAGE,

HOW COULD THIS HAPPEN?!,

THE PROMISE WAS NOT FULFILLED!

THUCK

YOU SAID YOU WOULD EXTERMINATE THOSE SAVAGE TRIBES...!

MY CLOTHES...!

!

CRACKLE

CRACKLE

STEP

WITHOUT IT,
I CANNOT BECOME
A "FLOWER."

I WON'T
BE ABLE TO
SEE
HAKU...!

IF I DON'T
HAVE MY
COMING-OF-AGE
ATTIRE...!

GRIP

YAYA.

HAKU...

HAKU...?!

PLEASE.

TAKE ME WITH YOU..

HOLD

SLIDE

AND THEN,

CLAD IN HER COMING-OF-AGE ATTIRE,

YAYA BECAME A FLOWER.

SHE WITHERED,

SOMEDAY SHE MAY BE THROWN AWAY,

AND TRAMPLED UNDERFOOT,

BUT SHE WAS HAKU'S FLOWER.

BUT THAT IS THE KIND OF FLOWER YAYA IS.

THUMP

THUMP

THUMP

THUMP

YAYA.

MMM...?

AWAKE?

MM...??

WHY WERE YOU CRYING, YAYA?

YOU SLEPT SOUNDLY.

GOOD MORNING, SWEETIE.

WHO KNOWS?

I'M NOT A BABY ANYMORE.

HAKU, PAT MY HEAD.

PERHAPS YOU HAD AN UNPLEASANT DREAM.

.....

WHAT A BIG BABY.

.....

HAKU

WOULDN'T WANT ME IF I DIDN'T WEAR CLOTHES, RIGHT?

...HAVE YOU GROWN TIRED OF TRAVELING?

NO.

IF YOU WON'T WEAR CLOTHES,

THEN I'LL HOLD YOU CLOSE.

WHEN BABIES ARE BORN, THEY WEAR NOTHING AT ALL.

SO SOMEONE'S ARMS BECOME THAT CHILD'S GARMENT.

IF YOU DON'T WEAR CLOTHES, YOU'LL CATCH COLD.

I WILL BECOME YOUR GARMENT.

...YAYA, YOU DO WORRY SO MUCH.

IT'S ALL RIGHT.

I LOVE YOU, YAYA.

I LOVE YOU TOO!

AFTER BEGINNING TO TRAVEL THROUGH "TIME" WITH HAKU,

YAYA BECAME "YAYA."

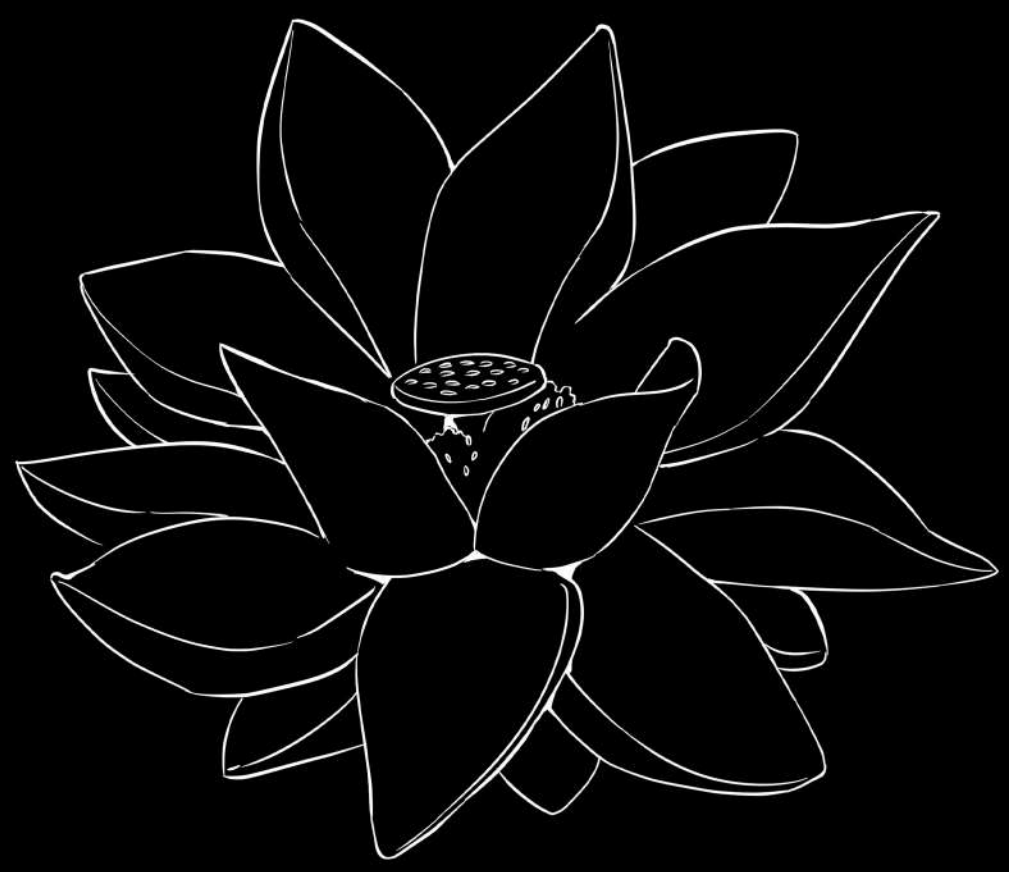
HAKU GAVE ME A NAME AND A NEW LIFE."

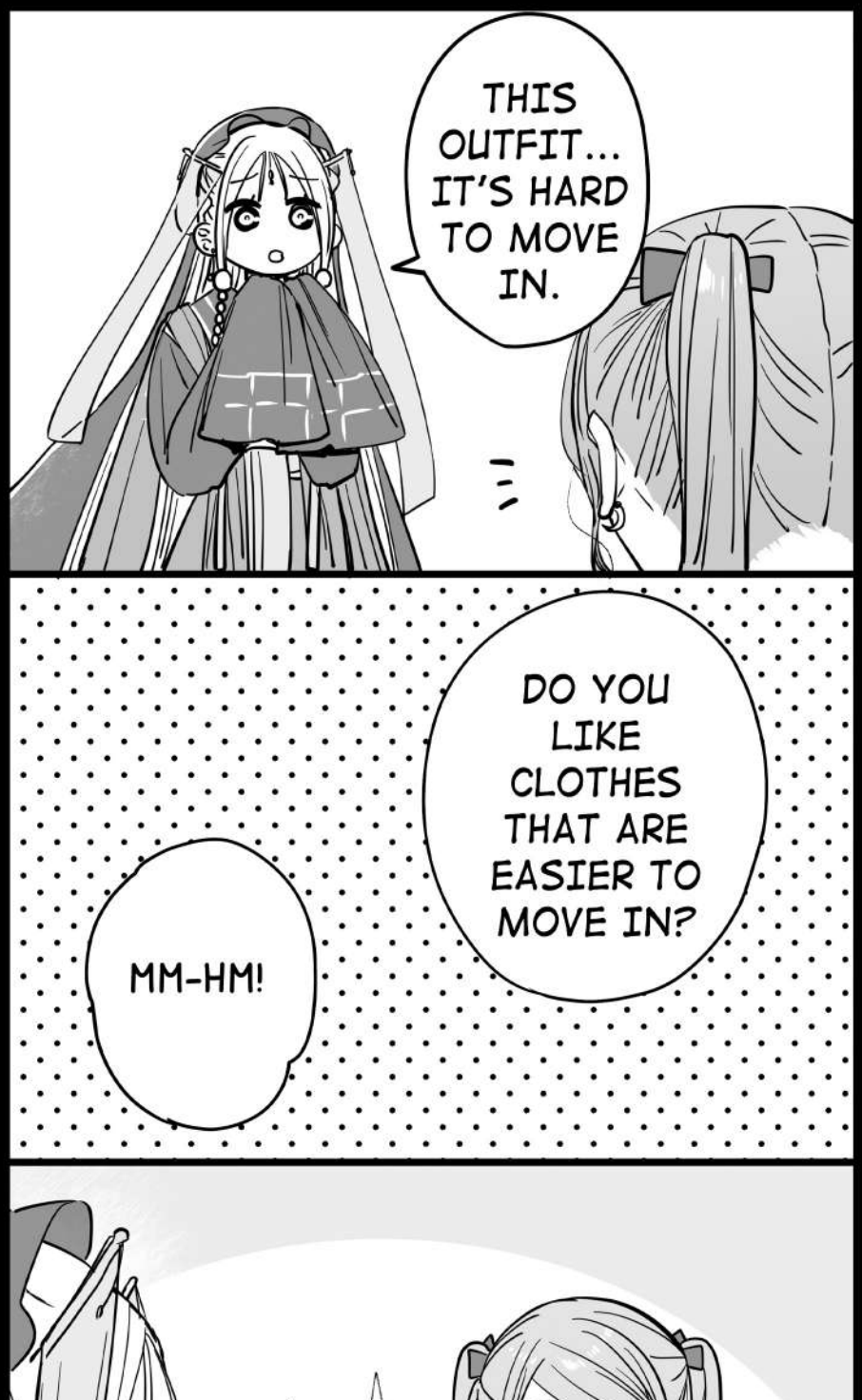
THE INCOMPLETE FLOWER BECAME A FLOWER,

AND BY HAKU'S SIDE, FOREVER,

KEPT ON BLOOMING.

THAT IS
THE STORY
OF HOW YAYA
AND HAKU FIRST
MET.




THIS OUTFIT... IT'S HARD TO MOVE IN.
DO YOU LIKE CLOTHES THAT ARE EASIER TO MOVE IN?
MM-HM!
!!
I'LL MAKE IT JUST THE WAY YOU WANT.
CUT IT, CUT IT!